

AP Art History: The Complete Exam Guide

All 10 content areas and the 250-work image set explained, the six essay types including attribution, and 10 hard practice questions.

Hi, I'm **Pigo!** I'll drop tips all through this guide.

**3 hrs**

1 hr multiple choice
+ 2 hrs essays

80+6

multiple-choice +
free-response questions

250

works in the
required image set

66–67%

scored 3 or higher
in recent years

INSIDE THIS GUIDE

01	The exam at a glance	2	06	10 traps that cost points	7
02	Section I: multiple choice	3	07	Your study roadmap to May	8
03	The 10 content areas	4	08	10 practice questions	9
04	Section II: free response	5	09	Answer key & explanations	11
05	Anatomy of a full-credit answer	6	10	Scores & exam-day checklist	12

01 THE EXAM AT A GLANCE

Two sections, one score

Your AP score (1–5) combines a multiple-choice section and six essays, each worth half. Both use color images of artworks, from prehistoric caves to contemporary installations.

50%

Section I · Multiple choice · 80 questions

50%

Section II · Free response · 6 questions

Exam structure

Section	Weight & timing	What you do
I · Multiple choice	50% of score 1 hour 80 questions	Sets of 2–3 questions on images of artworks, plus individual questions. Analyze visual and contextual elements, compare works, and attribute works you haven't studied.
II · Free response	50% of score 2 hours 6 questions	2 long essays (Comparison; Visual/Contextual Analysis) and 4 short essays (Visual Analysis; Contextual Analysis; Attribution; Continuity and Change).

FULLY DIGITAL

Everything happens in Bluebook

You answer every question, including the written responses, in College Board's **Bluebook** testing app. Responses are submitted automatically at the end. Practice typing timed answers before May.

THE IMAGE SET

250 required works

The course centers on **250 required works** across 10 content areas. Know each work's title, artist or culture, date, materials, and its function and context.

How to use this guide

Just starting?

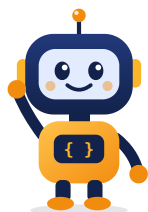
Read pages 2–6, then follow the roadmap on page 8 month by month.

Mid-year?

Check the traps on page 7 and drill the free-response playbook on page 6.

Exam in weeks?

Take the 10 questions on page 9 in 12 minutes, then use the final-four-weeks plan.



Pigo's tip: For every work, build an **index card**: identifying details, form, function, content and context. That card answers almost any question.

SECTION I

02 The multiple-choice section

80 questions in 60 minutes, only 45 seconds each. Instant recognition of the 250 works is what makes this pace possible.

80

questions, many image-based

0:45

seconds per question on average

50%

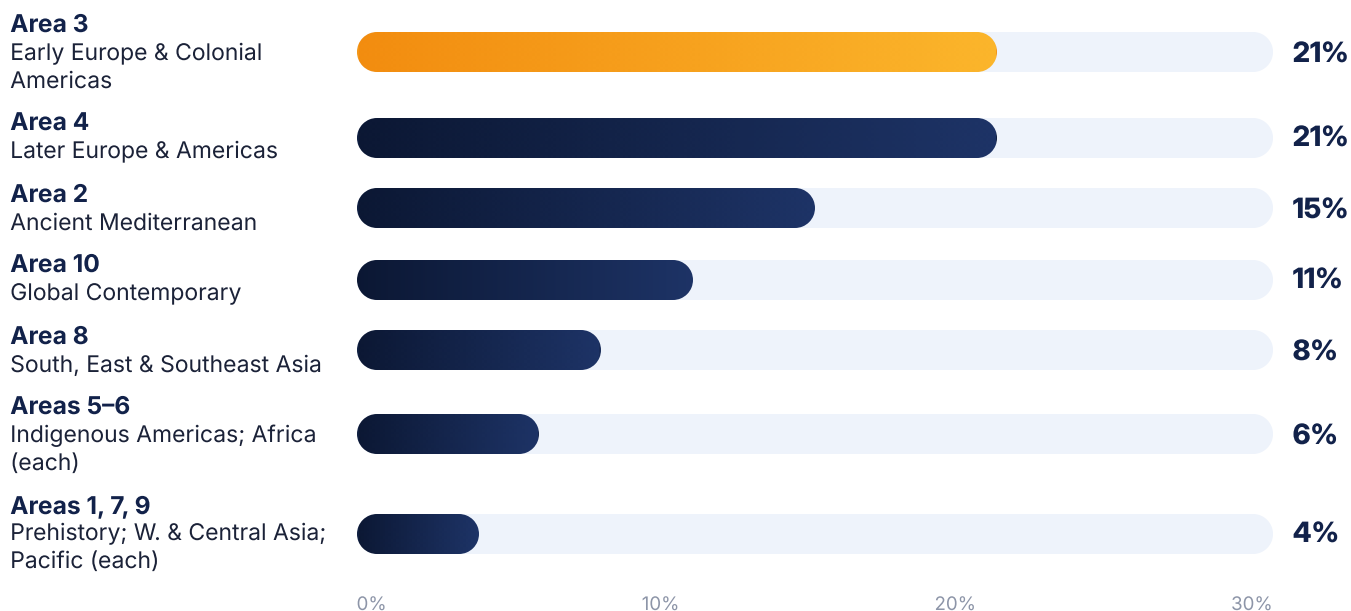
of your total AP score

0

points lost for a wrong answer, so never leave one blank

How the questions are weighted by unit

College Board gives an approximate share of the course for each content area.



What this means for your study time: European and American art (Areas 3–4) together are about 42%, but more than half the course covers the rest of the world. Every area appears on the exam.

Strategies that work on this section

- **Identify the work first:** title, culture and date often unlock the answer.
- **For unfamiliar works,** use style clues: materials, composition, figure style and subject.
- **Know the vocabulary:** contrapposto, chiaroscuro, iconography, hierarchical scale, registers.
- **Think about function:** who used the work, where, and why?
- **Move fast.** At 45 seconds per question, flag anything that needs more time.
- **Never leave a blank.** There is no penalty for guessing.

03 WHAT THE COURSE COVERS

The 10 content areas

The 250 works are organized into ten content areas. Know at least one key work and idea for each.

AREA 1 ~4%	Global Prehistory 30,000–500 BCE Know: cave paintings, megaliths and early sculpture; how art reflects survival, ritual and early societies.	AREA 2 ~15%	Ancient Mediterranean 3500 BCE–300 CE Know: Near Eastern, Egyptian, Greek, Etruscan and Roman art; idealism vs naturalism; architecture and political power.
AREA 3 ~21%	Early Europe & Colonial Americas 200–1750 CE Know: Byzantine, Islamic Spain, Romanesque and Gothic art; the Renaissance; Baroque; colonial art in the Americas.	AREA 4 ~21%	Later Europe & Americas 1750–1980 CE Know: Neoclassicism, Romanticism, Realism, Impressionism, modernism and abstraction; photography; art and industrialization.
AREA 5 ~6%	Indigenous Americas 1000 BCE–1980 CE Know: Mesoamerican, Andean and North American works; art tied to ritual, power and place.	AREA 6 ~6%	Africa 1100–1980 CE Know: masks, sculpture and architecture; art in performance and community; royal and spiritual power.
AREA 7 ~4%	West & Central Asia 500 BCE–1980 CE Know: Buddhist and Islamic art and architecture; calligraphy and pattern; the Kaaba and mosques.	AREA 8 ~8%	South, East & Southeast Asia 300 BCE–1980 CE Know: Buddhist and Hindu sculpture and temples; Chinese painting and ceramics; Japanese prints and gardens.
AREA 9 ~4%	The Pacific 700–1980 CE Know: navigation, ancestry and social status expressed through objects, textiles and architecture.	AREA 10 ~11%	Global Contemporary 1980 CE–present Know: installation, performance and digital art; identity, globalization and challenges to art traditions.

SECTION II

04 The 6 free-response questions

2 hours for 2 long essays and 4 short essays. Suggested times: 35 minutes for Q1, 25 for Q2 and 15 for each short essay.

Q1 · Long

Q2 · Long

Q3

Q4

Q5

Q6

Long essays are worth more points than short essays

Q1

Long essay: Comparison

~35 minutes

Compare a given work from the image set with another work you choose, analyzing similarities and differences in form, function or context.

Choose a second work you know in detail, from a different culture if possible.

Q2

Long essay: Visual/Contextual Analysis

~25 minutes

Choose a work that fits a theme and analyze how its visual elements and context convey meaning.

Identify the work fully: title, artist or culture, date, materials.

Q3-4

Visual and Contextual Analysis

~15 minutes each

Analyze a given work's form and techniques (visual) or its function, audience and setting (contextual).

Use specific visual evidence, such as composition, color and scale.

Q5-6

Attribution and Continuity & Change

~15 minutes each

Attribute an unfamiliar work to an artist, culture or style using evidence; explain how a work relates to earlier artistic traditions.

For attribution, compare it to a work you know from the image set.

◆ A time plan for the 120 minutes

Q1
35 min

Q2
25 min

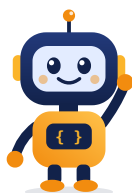
Q3
15

Q4
15

Q5
15

Q6
15

Suggested timing. Check how much time Bluebook recommends for each question on exam day.



Identify every work you write about with **at least two** details: title, artist or culture, date and materials.

05

FREE-RESPONSE PLAYBOOK

Anatomy of a strong answer

Here is a short-essay attribution prompt with a strong response, annotated to show where points come from.

PRACTICE TASK · WRITTEN BY ACT SAT GO

Practice prompt (attribution style): An unfamiliar marble sculpture shows a nude male figure standing with his weight on one leg, his hips and shoulders tilted in opposite directions, and calm, idealized facial features. (a) Attribute the work to a culture and period. (b) Use at least two visual details as evidence. (c) Compare it to a specific work from the image set.

Sample response

- ① (a) The sculpture is most likely Classical Greek, from the 5th century BCE, or a later Roman copy.
- ② (b) The figure's **contrapposto** stance, with weight on one leg and the hips and shoulders tilted in opposite directions, creates natural, relaxed movement.
- ③ Its **idealized**, calm face and balanced proportions reflect the Greek pursuit of perfect human form.
- ④ (c) Like Polykleitos's *Doryphoros*, which also uses contrapposto and an ideal system of proportions, this figure turns the human body into a model of harmony and order.

- ① **Make a specific attribution:** culture and approximate date.
- ② **Name the visual feature** with correct vocabulary.
- ③ **Explain what it shows** about the culture's values.
- ④ **Compare to a named work** from the image set.

Five habits for every essay

- 1 Identify each work with at least two details.
- 2 Use art vocabulary precisely.
- 3 Back every claim with a visual or contextual detail.
- 4 Answer every lettered part of the prompt.
- 5 Stuck on attribution? Reason from a work you know.

06 LEARN FROM OTHERS

10 traps that cost points

Meet **Glitch**. He lives in these ten mistakes. Squash each one before May.



01 Describing without analyzing

"The painting is blue" isn't analysis. Explain what the color does and why.

02 Weak identification

Identify works with title, artist or culture, date and materials. Vague IDs can lose points.

03 Ignoring function

Many works were made for ritual, power or memory, not display. Function is often the key.

04 Eurocentrism

Don't judge non-Western works by European standards. Explain them in their own context.

05 Mixing up periods

Archaic (stiff, kouros) vs Classical (contrapposto) vs Hellenistic (dramatic emotion).

06 Choosing a weak comparison work

Pick a second work you know well and that truly connects to the prompt.

07 Attribution without evidence

Attribution needs specific visual features that link to a known style.

08 Running out of time

Six essays in two hours. Keep short essays to about 15 minutes.

09 Skipping content areas

Every content area appears. Know at least a few works from each.

10 Forgetting context

Patrons, audiences, politics and religion shape meaning. Include them.

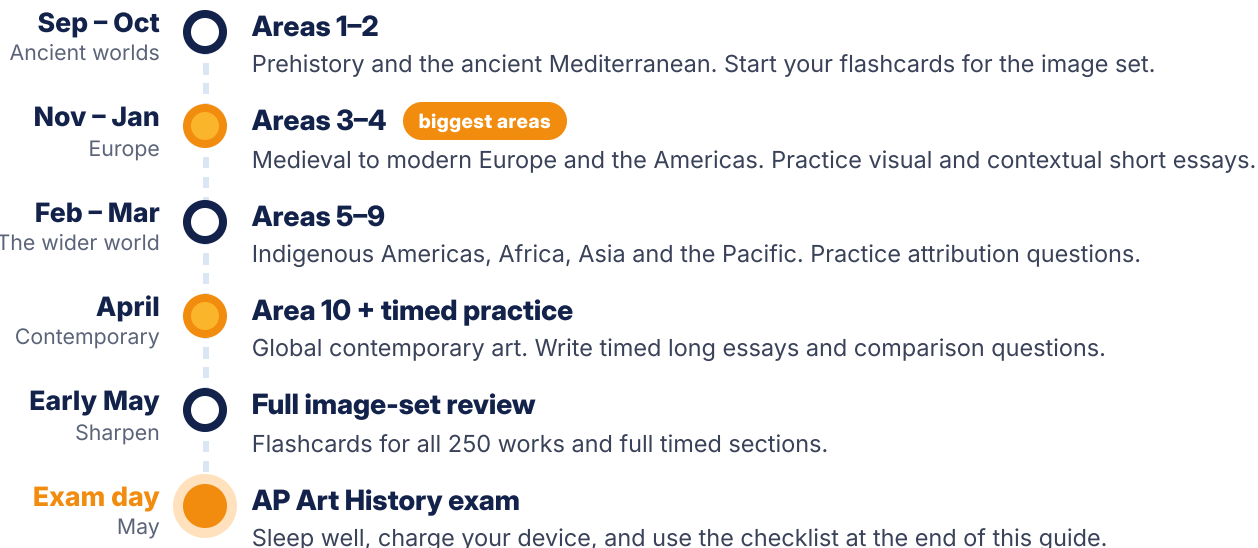
Quick self-check: for any five works in the image set, can you give the culture, date, material, function and one key visual feature without notes?



PLAN YOUR YEAR

Your study roadmap to May

A steady plan beats a last-minute rush. Review image-set flashcards daily, about 10 works a day.



The final four weeks

Week	Focus	Target
4 weeks out	Diagnose: 40 multiple-choice questions plus one long essay	List your weakest content areas
3 weeks out	Flashcards: 25 works a day	Full ID for every work
2 weeks out	Full 3-hour practice exam	Finish all six essays
Final week	Light review: weak areas, vocabulary, traps list	Rest the night before

08 TEST YOURSELF

10 practice questions

Original questions written by ACT SAT GO in the style of the exam, pitched at the harder end. Give yourself **12 minutes** for all ten, then check page 11.

1 AREA 2 • GREECE

Which feature distinguishes Classical Greek sculpture from Archaic sculpture such as the kouros?

- A Rigid, frontal poses
- B The use of bright paint for the first time
- C Hierarchical scale
- D Contrapposto and more naturalistic anatomy

2 AREA 2 • EGYPT

In ancient Egyptian art, the pharaoh is often shown larger than other figures. This convention is called:

- A hierarchical scale
- B foreshortening
- C chiaroscuro
- D atmospheric perspective

3 AREA 3 • GOTHIC

Gothic cathedrals use flying buttresses mainly so that:

- A the building can be built faster
- B the roof can be made of wood
- C walls can be thinner and filled with large stained-glass windows
- D the interior can be darker

4 AREA 3 • RENAISSANCE

Linear perspective, developed in 15th-century Florence, allowed artists to:

- A mix oil paint with egg tempera
- B create the illusion of three-dimensional space on a flat surface
- C avoid religious subjects
- D paint only portraits

5 AREA 4 • MODERNISM

Impressionist painters in the late 1800s were especially interested in:

- A capturing changing light and modern life with visible brushstrokes
- B precise, smooth brushwork and historical subjects
- C religious altarpieces for churches
- D carving monumental stone sculpture

6 AREA 6 • AFRICA

Many African masks in the image set are best understood as objects that:

- A were made only for display in museums
- B were purely decorative
- C were activated in performance, with music and costume, within community rituals
- D were imported from Europe

7 AREA 7 • ISLAMIC ART

The frequent use of calligraphy and geometric pattern in Islamic religious architecture is related to:

- A a lack of skilled painters
- B the avoidance of figural images in religious spaces
- C Roman building techniques
- D the Protestant Reformation

8 AREA 8 • ASIA

Japanese woodblock prints (ukiyo-e) of the Edo period often depicted:

- A Buddhist sutras only
- B portraits of European kings
- C abstract geometric designs
- D scenes of urban pleasure, actors and landscapes for a broad audience

08 TEST YOURSELF (continued)

9 AREA 10 · CONTEMPORARY

Many contemporary artists use installation and performance mainly to:

- A** involve the viewer's space and experience and question traditional ideas of art
- B** create objects that can easily be sold
- C** copy Renaissance paintings
- D** avoid social and political subjects

10 ATTRIBUTION

An unfamiliar painting shows dramatic contrasts of light and dark, a moment of intense action, and figures pushed close to the viewer. It is most likely from which period?

- A** Gothic
- B** Impressionist
- C** Byzantine
- D** Baroque

09

CHECK YOUR WORK

Answer key & explanations

Read every explanation, even for questions you got right. Each one points to a pattern that keeps coming back on the exam.

#	Answer	Why
1	D	Classical sculptors introduced contrapposto and naturalistic anatomy, replacing the stiff, frontal Archaic kouros pose.
2	A	Hierarchical scale shows importance through size, so the pharaoh appears largest.
3	C	Flying buttresses carry the vaults' outward thrust, so walls can be thinner and opened up with stained glass.
4	B	Linear perspective uses a vanishing point and orthogonals to create convincing three-dimensional space.
5	A	Impressionists painted modern life and changing light, often outdoors, with loose, visible brushwork.
6	C	Masks were activated in performance, with costume, music and movement, within community and ritual life.
7	B	Many Islamic religious spaces avoid figural images, so calligraphy and geometric pattern carry meaning and beauty.
8	D	Ukiyo-e ("pictures of the floating world") showed urban entertainment, actors and later landscapes, sold to a broad public.
9	A	Installation and performance involve the viewer's experience and challenge ideas of art as a single, sellable object.
10	D · Baroque	Strong chiaroscuro, dramatic action and figures close to the viewer are hallmarks of Baroque painting (for example, Caravaggio).

9–10

Strong. Move on to full timed free-response practice.

6–8

On track. Revisit the unit behind every miss on page 4.

0–5

Build foundations now. Make flashcards for the image set and review 10 works a day.

10 KNOW THE TARGET

How students score

In recent years, about 66–67% of students earned a 3 or higher on AP Art History, and about 15–16% earned a 5. Steady preparation is what moves a score up a full point.

66–67%

of students earned a 3 or higher in recent years

15–16%

earned the top score of 5 in recent years

3+

is the score many colleges accept for credit or placement

What each AP score means

5

Extremely well qualified

4

Very well qualified

3

Qualified

2

Possibly qualified

1

No recommendation

Ranges reflect recent College Board score distributions and shift a little each year. Credit and placement policies vary by college, so check each college's AP policy.

Exam-day checklist

- ☐ **Bluebook** is installed and updated, and your device passed the exam check
- ☐ Device **fully charged**, with the charger packed
- ☐ Admission ticket and photo ID, as your school requires
- ☐ Confirm your **exam day and start time** in May with your AP coordinator
- ☐ Plan your time: **45 s** per multiple-choice question; **35 + 25 min** for the long essays and **15 min** per short essay
- ☐ Answer **every** multiple-choice question. Wrong answers don't lose points
- ☐ Review your **image-set flashcards** the night before
- ☐ Practice typing a 15-minute short essay

In the essays: identify every work with at least two details, use precise art vocabulary, support each claim with visual or contextual evidence, and compare to named works from the image set.



ACT SAT GO • 1-ON-1 AP TUTORING

Aiming for a 5? Get a personal AP Art History plan.

Book a free diagnostic lesson. We'll find your weakest units, review your practice responses, and give you a week-by-week plan to exam day in May.

Book a free diagnostic lesson →



Scan to book
www.actsatgo.com/consultation

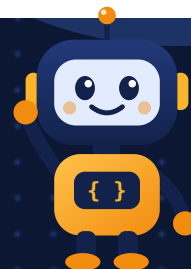


Image-set tutoring

Live 1-on-1 sessions on all 10 content areas, with identification and attribution drills.

Essay coaching

Write long and short essays and get them scored against rubric-style criteria.

Timed exam practice

Full-length multiple-choice sets with score reports, so you see progress before May.

◆ Contact us

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